like minister Nitesh Rane and Gopichand Padalkar. Ajit's constituency—Baramati—has 60,000 Muslims. Of the state's 10 Muslim MLAs, two are NCP. It also has the sole Muslim face in the state cabinet—medical education minister Hasan Mushrif.

'UNNATURAL' PROXIMITY

When the Qureshi butcher community went on strike and refused to buy and cull buffaloes, citing harassment by cow vigilantes, it was Ajit who stepped in to try break the impasse. But these ties are under strain. The discomfiture peaked with NCP MLA Sangram Jagtap's vituperative statements. He had in fact pressed on despite Ajit's warnings—unprecedented in the NCP. The "unnatural" proximity with the BJP seems to be rubbing off. A costly mutation, if so, with identity, ideology and livelihood issues intertwined.

Takeaways

- **Ajit Pawar's wife, RS MP Sunetra Pawar, seen at RSS women's wing event, causes a ruckus**
- **Rival NCP(SP) accuses Ajit of "double standards", says NCP will soon capitulate to saffron**
- **NCP base is mostly Maratha, also includes Muslims, Dalits**

A leader admits the bulk of the NCP support base comes from those who had a generational commitment to the old parent Congress. "Cow vigilantism affects the livelihoods of Dalits and Muslims, who have a strong presence in Baramati. They may shift allegiance in the coming local body polls...abandoned cattle gone feral are a major problem in rural areas," he adds.

NCP elders believe there's still tactical space here, without surrendering. "We have ideological differences, making things awkward. But Ajitdada has conveyed to Muslims that he stands by them," says one. But there are sceptics, including partymen in Pune who say the BJP is gerrymandering municipal wards in its favour. They are among those who see a zero sum game. ■



▶ GUJARAT

A WASTELAND OF THE NARMADA

The Little Rann of Kutch "becomes a sea", causing eco havoc, as precious river water flows in unused

By **Jumana Shah in Surendranagar**

HOW DID THE LITTLE RANN of Kutch, all 65 sq. km of it, turn into a salt lake filled with Narmada water? Swimming somewhere within that question is an old quandary: how to manage Narmada waters across the length and breadth of Gujarat. Answers exist, but only in theory. The result: for over a decade, an overrun of lakhs of litres of fresh water from Narmada canals, meant to irrigate farmlands in border villages, has been going waste, flowing into the desert-like Little Rann almost round the year.

In theory, the Narmada's use is bound by strict norms, each drop accounted for, with farmer-led Water Use Associations (WUAs) formally requisitioning the Sardar Sarovar Narmada Nigam Ltd (SSNNL) for the exact quantums they need. In practice, ad hocism flows unhindered. "On an average day, the local MLA or heavyweight will call an SSNNL officer and seek water for a few villages based on back-of-the-envelope estimates by farmers," says environmentalist Rohit Prajapati, who has been named to a special committee set up by the State Human Rights Commission (SHRC) on the directives of the Gujarat